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Curing the Poverty Curse

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Curing the Poverty Curse

He who ignores discipline comes to poverty and shame, but whoever heeds correction is honored. (Proverbs 13:18)

He who works his land will have abundant food, but the one who chases fantasies will have his fill of poverty. (Proverbs 28:19)

A stingy man is eager to get rich and is unaware that poverty awaits him. (Proverbs 28:22)

One man gives freely, yet gains even more; another withholds unduly, but comes to poverty. (Proverbs 11:24)

In the previous chapter, we learned that there are three marks of the person rushing headlong to poverty: (1) laziness; (2) “cheap talk”, talk without action; and (3) substance abuse. In the verses which form the focus of this chapter, we discover more factors which launch one toward the poorhouse.

The fourth principle is disregard for discipline and correction as described in Proverbs 13:18. Picture the rebellious teenager, the ghetto gang member, the arrogant and unteachable know-it-all, the criminal recidivist, and the prodigal child. All possess one trait which will pretty much assure their poverty—refusal to accept correction and discipline. This refusal detours a person from the goal of self-sufficiency and prosperity. In my first seminar at a major stock brokerage company on investing, I was told, “Never invest bread money, never risk the roof over your head, and don’t be greedy.” On that last point, the stockbroker explained, “Bulls make money, and bears make money, but pigs never do.” If I had ignored his counsel, I might own no house, be sweating food for my family, and have insurmountable debt. Instead, I have all I need and owe nobody.

Principle: Wisdom and wealth are spouses in a covenant bond—as are stupidity and poverty. Only death separates them.

As a visionary with the gift of faith, I confess to being a “sucker for a big idea.” Give me a dream, an awesome scheme, or a global plan and watch me get a faraway look in my eyes. My staff used to make a motion like they were reeling in a kite when I would slip into this mode! Vision is a great gift and a lethal one. If the dream isn’t practical, it can consume immense time and money with nothing to show for it in the end.

The sages of Israel observed that “chasing fantasies” puts one on the freeway to the homeless shelter. How many times, consulting in entertainment, have I observed the proverbial “starving artist” living hand to mouth sure that “the big break” is just around the corner. I’ve seen writers, performers, and other creatives refuse to get any kind of regular work to sustain themselves for decades while they chase their dreams. Our organization has helped feed them, pay their rent, and ward off their debt collectors...without remedy. Folly.

Principle: The one who chases mirages in the desert will inevitably suffer from the thirst that each vanishing oasis creates. Only sacrifice in pursuit of God’s reality brings rewards.

Creating precedent for Jesus’ teaching that “In whatever measure you give it will be given back to you, Proverbs links poverty to stinginess! In more than one passage, giving generously is described as a key to material blessing. Hoarding or withholding from others is tied to impoverishment. It’s the upside-down Kingdom principle: lavish giving begets lavish receiving...and God’s blessing. I laugh inwardly when I hear some dreamer say, “If God makes me wealthy, I will give generously.” If one does not give in his “poverty,” he will never give in his prosperity. Someone has suggested that we should tithe on the income we’d like to have! Psalm 37:21 says, “The wicked borrow and do not repay, but the righteous give generously.”

Principle: Confounding all earthly economic principles, giving all you have is the key to being free from need and having ample to give more.

Show me a lazy, big-talking, substance-abusing, stingy rebel who chases dreams instead of working for them; and I’ll show you a person who is racing to a debtor’s prison. The Book says so.

[from “*Wisdom for the Trenches*” by Dr. Larry W. Poland]

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In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

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